EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

What Happens at the End of Days? Saadiah vs the Rambam

Given Monday 9 June 2025 · Emunot VeDeot, Essay 7:8-9

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 7 (The Resurrection of the Dead), the end of Chapter 8 and Chapter 9, with a summary of the whole essay

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 9 June 2025, on Zoom

These notes are based on a transcript of the recording.

The Plan for Tonight

The last class on the seventh essay, on **תחיית המתים**. The Rabbi set out three tasks:

1. Finish **Chapters 8 and 9**: the last four of Saadia's ten questions about resurrection, and his closing chapter.
2. Give a **synopsis of Saadia's whole approach** to the end of days.
3. Compare it with the **other approaches among the Rishonim** on how the three great promises fit together: **משיח**, **תחיית המתים** and **עולם הבא**.

"Of course, there are more small details such as Eliyahu HaNavi, the Beit HaMikdash, but I'm not going to go into that." The focus is on how those three come together.

Recap: The First Six Questions

In Chapter 8 Saadia works through ten questions people ask about resurrection. Last week covered the first six:

1. **There are two resurrections.** One happens in this world and ushers in the Messianic era. It is reserved for the Jewish people, "for those who have been through the *galut*, those who have suffered in exile." The second comes with **עולם הבא**, when everyone else who merits it, including the righteous of the nations, is resurrected for eternity.
2. **Those resurrected in this world do not die again.** After a period of a few hundred years they are transported straight into the new world of Olam HaBa. "There's no death again."
3. **There will be enough space.** Saadia "did all the maths" and concluded there is plenty of room.
4. **We will recognise our loved ones** and relatives.

5. **People rise with their physical blemishes** so that they can be recognised. Once everyone has recognised one another, they are miraculously healed.
6. **Life goes on as normal** after the first resurrection: people eat, drink, marry and have children.

Question Seven: How Do We Pass into a World Without Eating?

איך יחיה את כל עולם הבא שאין בו אכילה ולא בעילה וכל הנאות שנהגו בהם בעולם הזה

Everyone agrees on what the Gemara says: **העולם הבא אין בו לא אכילה ולא שתיה**, in Olam HaBa there is no eating and no drinking. But according to Saadia, the first resurrection happens in this world. Someone dies today, Mashiach comes tomorrow, and he is resurrected. Now he eats, drinks and marries. Then he is to be transported, with his body, into a world with no eating, no drinking and no procreation. How does a body that has grown used to all this suddenly do without it?

Saadia answers: **just like Moshe Rabbeinu.**

כמו שנהג משה רבנו עליו השלום... ועמד בלעדיהם ארבעים יום בהר סיני שלשה פעמים בחייו

Moshe was a human being. He ate, he drank, he was married and had children. Yet three times in his life, for forty days each time (120 days in all), he went without these things. The day before he went up the mountain he was eating and drinking, and then on the mountain the Torah says plainly: **לחם לא אכלתי ומים לא שתיתי**, "I did not eat bread and I did not drink water."

So it is possible to have a body and be free of its needs. In the same way, those living in the Messianic world will be carried over into Olam HaBa. "We will refine this more when we see the Ramchal's approach, but remember this point."

Question Eight: Can the Resurrected Still Sin?

This, said the Rabbi, "is really interesting."

כיון שהמחויים בימי הישועה הם מונחים לבחירתם בעבודה

Saadia takes it as a certainty that **there will be free choice during the time of resurrection**. That raises a danger. A righteous person dies yesterday and is resurrected today. This world goes on, and so does free will. What if he now makes the wrong choices and loses the real reward, the **גמול** of Olam HaBa? Resurrection could turn out to be bad for him.

Saadia's answer: God knows in advance

לא הבטיח הצדיקים שבעולם הבא גמולם מתמיד אלא בידיעתו שהם בוחרים בעבודה ולא במרי. כן אמר אחר שיודע מה שיהיה, לא הבטיח תחיית המתים צדיקי ישראל עד שידע כי בימות המשיח יבחרו בעבודה ולא במרי

God knows the future. (Saadia's way of reconciling free will with God's foreknowledge was covered in Essay 4.) **He only resurrects, and only gives Olam HaBa to, those He knows will make the right choices** in the time of resurrection and in Olam HaBa itself.

Free will in Olam HaBa itself?

"I went over this a few times trying to make sure I understood this correctly, because I'm so used to the other understanding." The striking point is that Saadia answers by comparing the resurrected to **those already in Olam HaBa**. In other words, **Saadia holds that even in Olam HaBa there is still an element of free will.** "This may sound shocking to you."

The usual narrative, the way the **Rambam** puts it "black and white," the way the **Ramchal** portrays it, and the way we are generally taught, is that **this world is the world of work and of choice, and choice comes to an end in Olam HaBa.** "If I can say, it makes the most sense." But Saadia says otherwise.

Where might he get this from? The Rabbi could not find a direct source, but pointed to something along these lines:

- The verse we say before Minchah: **ילכו מחיל אל חיל יראה אל אלהים בציון**, "they go from strength to strength."
- The Gemara on the last page of Berachot: the righteous have no rest, **not in this world and not in the World to Come**.

There are different understandings of that Gemara, but Saadia probably read it to mean that **work does not end in Olam HaBa**. There is continuous elevation, because there are always choices to make.

"For me, I find this very, very difficult to understand. What is the purpose of having continuous *bechirah*? Surely the purpose of free will is to be able to make choices for a limited period of time, but then there comes a time when choice comes to an end, and now we reap the consequences of our choices."

What everyone agrees on: free will in the days of Mashiach

The Rabbi stressed that almost everyone after Saadia disagrees with him about Olam HaBa: there is a time for *bechirah* in this world, and then it ends. But **the first half of what Saadia says is agreed: in the days of Mashiach there will still be free choice.**

Here he brought **Rav Dessler**, who has an essay on this. "Perhaps we're just anachronising it from Rav Dessler to Saadia," but it may be what Saadia meant. In the Messianic era, free will will **no longer be a choice between good and bad, but between good and better.**

- There will be no temptation to do wrong, because **ומלאה הארץ דעה את ה׳**, the land will be full of the knowledge of Hashem.
- But *how* I do the good, to what extent, with what intention: all of that is still free choice.
- The Rabbi compared this to what the *sefarim* write about **Adam HaRishon before the sin**. How could he sin without a *yetzer hara*? One idea is that the choice to do bad existed, but it was **external** to him. By sinning he brought it inside, which made it a much greater difficulty.

So in Messianic times there will be *bechirah*, "no longer between bad and good, but between good and excellent," and those choices will have consequences for one's portion in Olam HaBa. Once we reach Olam HaBa itself, the general consensus is that choice is over. Saadia held otherwise, "which is fascinating."

Question Nine: Is There Reward for Service in the Days of Mashiach?

אם יש להם על עבודה היא בימות המשיח גמול

Yes, "100%." Just as the righteous are rewarded for their service in this world, so they will be in the days of Mashiach. **It is not possible to have service without reward.** And whatever good is done in the Messianic era will be added to one's earlier merits and rewarded in Olam HaBa. Free will continues in the days of Mashiach, and so does reward for how we use it.

Question Ten: What About Those Who Are Alive When It Happens?

A very specific question. Mashiach comes, the resurrection begins, and everyone of the last few thousand years is resurrected. "May we see it in our days." It works for those who were dead. But what about those **alive at the time**, and those **born during the Messianic era**? Remember, in those days people eat, drink and have children. Do they have to die and come back to life?

Saadia says **there is no tradition on this**. Nothing explicit comes from the Hachamim, so there are three approaches:

	Approach
1	They will **never die**, because there is no more death; they simply carry on living
2	They will **die and come back to life**, to be equal with those who died and rose
3	**שיחיו שנים רבות וימותו וילכו לעולם הבא**: they will live many years, then die, and go on to Olam HaBa

Saadia prefers the third, "which I like" too. Unlike the resurrected, who never die again, those who were alive will die, and they will **not** get a second resurrection in this world. They will be resurrected only once, for Olam HaBa.

The reason: resurrection is the reward of exile

Saadia explains why: **the promise of resurrection in the redemption was made only to those who went through the exile.** Those who suffered "the death of exile" are owed a resurrection in this world. If you never went through that, there is no need for one. You live through the days of Mashiach, and when your time comes you die, and you are resurrected for the final time in Olam HaBa.

Very long lives

Saadia stresses that their lives will be very long, perhaps four or five hundred years, so that dying at a hundred will be like dying young:

כי הנער בן מאה שנה ימות והחוטא בן מאה שנה יקולל (Yeshayahu 65:20)

The Rabbi drew out the second half. Normally, if a hundred-year-old does something foolish, we overlook it because he is an old man. In the days of Mashiach, a hundred-year-old who sins will be told off, because at a hundred he is still a youth. Life spans will be like those of the early generations:

(Yeshayahu 65:22) **לא יבנו ואחר ישב לא יטעו ואחר יאכל כי כימי העץ ימי עמי ומעשה ידיהם יבלו בחירי**

That is the end of Chapter 8.

Chapter 9: Six Reasons to Hold On to This Belief

The final chapter is very short. Saadia explains why he spent so long on resurrection and wrote it all down: he wanted it to be a teaching for Israel, and he saw great benefit in it. He gives six reasons:

1. **It is one of the Creator's greatest signs.** Seeing it will increase our trust in Hashem's ability.
2. **All the prophets will be gathered together**, with the righteous kings and the great Hachamim. "What would we give to see one prophet now? If I could give you an hour with Moshe Rabbeinu, an hour with Yeshayahu, an hour with Rashi, an hour with the Rambam... we would go crazy about that. You're going to see them all together."
3. **We will be reunited with our relatives**: the son with his father, a brother with his brother, a lover with his beloved, and the student with his Rabbi. "Those are the four loves." "I'll see my students again, my parents again, my children again, my siblings again. It's beautiful."
4. **Those who come back will tell us** what happened to them in the time they were dead. "It's going to be fascinating to know."
5. **All the generations of Bnei Yisrael** will come together, in great splendour, and each generation will speak of its own.
6. **It strengthens our belief in Olam HaBa.** Once we have seen this promise fulfilled, we can trust that all the later promises will be fulfilled too: **ביום ההוא... הנה אלהינו זה קוינו לו ויושיענו**, "on that day it will be said: this is our God, we hoped for Him and He saved us."

Saadia ends with a personal prayer: that he will merit to be among those who see it, either alive in his own lifetime or, at the very least, by being resurrected to see it. And he blesses God, who is faithful to keep His promises.

Saadia's Full Picture of the End of Days

With the essay finished, the Rabbi summarised Saadia's eschatology "in a few sentences."

Saadia expected it soon. In a few places in the essay you can see that he felt it could come today or tomorrow. When he calculated how much space would be needed, he only counted the dead up to his own generation. "This is a thousand years ago. We're waiting." The Rabbi added his own inference: Saadia does not say this, but he probably held, with the Gemara, that this world lasts 6,000 years. We are now in 5785, so even if Mashiach came today, the period of the first resurrection would be at most about 215 years.

The sequence:

1. **Mashiach comes**, and with him the first resurrection, for the righteous of Bnei Yisrael.
2. The resurrected, and those of us alive at the time, **eat, drink, marry, have children and make choices**. There is *bechirah*, and life continues as usual. For the resurrected it is a very long life, and for the living a long one too.

3. **Those alive when Mashiach came** eventually die, and are resurrected later into Olam HaBa.
4. **Those who were resurrected** live on until the end of this world and are **transported directly** into Olam HaBa, with no second death.
5. Then **the real Olam HaBa begins**: a **new world**, which does not yet exist. The righteous of the nations of all the generations are resurrected into it, and everyone lives together for eternity, **body and soul**.

For Saadia, then, **resurrection is in a sense synonymous with Olam HaBa**. The second resurrection begins the new world. The Messianic era is a temporary stage, with choice, reward and consequences, and it is a prelude: "slowly warming us up" for the real thing.

The Rambam: Three Separate Things

"The Rambam's approach is extremely different." For the Rambam, **Mashiach is one thing, resurrection is another, and Olam HaBa is another.** They cannot be equated.

- **Olam HaBa is the pinnacle**, what everything is for. It is a state of pure consciousness, the soul and nothing else. No body, no physicality, no eating, no drinking.
- **It is not a new world somewhere in the future.** "It's when we die, that's Olam HaBa." If you die today, you reach Olam HaBa today.
- **Resurrection is a bodily resurrection, but in this world and for a limited time.** In the Messianic era, those who died will be brought back. They will eat, drink and have children, and then die again and return to Olam HaBa.

The Rambam wrote, in his letter on resurrection, that people drive him mad with questions about what will happen when Mashiach comes: will it be like this, will it be like that. "Maybe he was referring to Saadia." He would not get involved. Everyone wants to know whether money will grow on trees in the days of Mashiach, or, as the Gemara says, clothes growing on trees. "That's not the important thing." He wished people would ask about Olam HaBa, which is what really matters.

The Abarbanel's question

The Abarbanel already raises the major difficulty with the Rambam. If the pinnacle is the pure spiritual consciousness of Olam HaBa, **why bring someone out of it** to spend another hundred or two hundred years in this world? For Saadia it makes sense: the Messianic era is a warm-up for the real thing. For the Rambam it is a step backwards. "That's very difficult. I don't have an answer to that. I'm not sure if there is an answer to that question."

The Ramban: Resurrection Leads into Olam HaBa

The **Ramban** challenged the Rambam with a number of proofs. The Rabbi gave one.

The Mishnah says **כל ישראל יש להם חלק לעולם הבא**, except for certain people, the first being **one who denies the resurrection of the dead**. Why should denying one belief cost a person his Olam HaBa? The Gemara answers:

הוא כפר בתחיית המתים, לפיכך לא יהיה לו חלק בתחיית המתים, שכל מדותיו של הקדוש ברוך הוא מדה כנגד מדה (Sanhedrin 90a)

Measure for measure: you denied resurrection, so you will not have a portion in it, and so you are excluded from Olam HaBa. The Ramban concludes that **resurrection and Olam HaBa are bound up together**: resurrection ushers in the world to come.

Gan Eden: the waiting room

The Ramban takes on Saadia's approach and refines it, and the **Kabbalists** and the **Ramchal** (Rav Moshe Chaim Luzzatto) follow him. If Olam HaBa is a world that does not yet exist, where is someone who dies today? He is in **גן עדן**, also called **עולם הנשמות**, the world of souls. It is a temporary place, a taste (*me'ein*) of what is to come, but **only for the soul**, which waits for resurrection.

Why is that not the real thing? Because, as the Ramban writes, and many echoed after him, **the body did the work in this world, so the body must receive the reward as well.** The real Olam HaBa has to be body and soul together, in the new world that will be created.

The proof from an invitation

The Gemara often says of a person who did teshuvah that a heavenly voice declared him **מזומן לחיי העולם הבא**, "invited to the life of the World to Come." According to the Rambam, you are not invited: when you die, you are there. According to the Ramban this phrase is a proof. "You got an invitation for a wedding in a few months' time. You don't have it yet. It hasn't come yet."

The Ramchal and Rabbeinu Bachya

The Ramchal goes further still. He accepts the whole sequence of Saadia and the Ramban: you die, you are in the world of souls, you wait for Mashiach, then there is resurrection, then Olam HaBa begins, body and soul together. But, coming back to Moshe on the mountain, there will be **phases in Olam HaBa**: continuous growth and elevation from level to level. That is what **ילכו מחיל אל חיל** means.

Rabbeinu Bachya takes the same approach as the Ramban and Saadia. The Rabbi read his presentation. The Rambam's opinion is that the resurrected will eat, drink, have children and live long lives, and then die and begin Olam HaBa, since there can be no bodily functions in the next world. Rabbeinu Bachya responds:

לא כן דעת חכמי התלמוד והקבלה

That is not the view of the Sages of the Talmud and the Kabbalah.

In their view **there is no death after resurrection.** And it must be body and soul together: just as they both strove to keep the mitzvot and toiled in them, so they will be rewarded together, for **אין הקדוש ברוך הוא מקפח שכר כל בריה**, Hashem does not withhold the reward of any creature.

Many Rishonim followed this approach, including the **Rashba** and the **Ritva**. Others followed the Rambam. The **Abarbanel** brings both opinions and says he prefers the Rambam's.

The Dispute Is Smaller Than It Looks

The Rabbi ended with one point: "the *machloket* we're making is much bigger than it really is."

Even Saadia and the Ramban, who believe in a new world with a body in it, must accept the Gemara that **in Olam HaBa there is no eating and no drinking**. So what kind of body is it?

- The **Ramban** and **Rabbeinu Bachya** explain that the body is there, because it must receive its reward, but it is **secondary to the soul**. Just like Moshe on the mountain: he was not divested of his body, "it's not like he died," but the body had no more desire to eat or drink. It was totally subdued to the soul.
- The **Ramchal** develops this into phases. At first the body is there and you sense its pull, but it is subdued, "like a guest in someone's house": maybe he wants to do something wrong, but he can't, he's a guest. Then it rises higher, to where the temptation is gone altogether, and higher still.

So according to the Ramban there is a body, according to Saadia there is a body, according to the Ramchal there is a body, but it is **a refined body (גוף זך)**. "You can't compare it to our body now." No eating, no drinking, no excretion. "A body which just follows the soul." The Rambam says pure soul.

There remain **major differences** between the Rambam and Saadia: whether Olam HaBa is a new world or what happens when you die, and whether there is death after resurrection. But on what we will be like in Olam HaBa, body and soul or soul alone, "the difference between those two opinions is actually very minute," because even for those who say body and soul, it will not be the body we know.

Summary

1. **Question 7:** the resurrected will pass into a world with no eating or drinking just as **Moshe** lived on the mountain without them, three times for forty days.
2. **Question 8:** there will be **free will in the days of Mashiach**, and God only resurrects those He knows will choose well. Saadia even holds there is **free will in Olam HaBa**, which almost everyone after him rejects. Rav Dessler: in Messianic times the choice is between good and better.
3. **Question 9:** there is **reward** for service in the days of Mashiach.
4. **Question 10:** those alive when Mashiach comes will live very long lives, die, and be resurrected only for Olam HaBa, because the first resurrection is the reward of **those who suffered exile**.
5. **Chapter 9:** six reasons the belief matters, from seeing Hashem's power to meeting the prophets, our families and all the generations, to strengthening our faith in Olam HaBa.
6. **Saadia:** Mashiach and the first resurrection are a prelude in this world; Olam HaBa is a **new world of body and soul**. Followed by the Ramban, Rabbeinu Bachya, the Ramchal, the Rashba and the Ritva.
7. **The Rambam:** Olam HaBa is the **soul alone**, reached at death; resurrection is temporary and in this world. The Abarbanel prefers it, but asks why anyone would be brought back.
8. **The gap is smaller than it seems:** the body of Olam HaBa, for those who hold there is one, is a **refined body** wholly subdued to the soul.

Coming Up

That concludes the seventh essay. Three essays remain: **Essay 8 on Mashiach**, **Essay 9 on Olam HaBa** (reward and punishment), and **Essay 10 on musar**, general conduct and behaviour. There is no shiur next week. Essay 8 begins in two weeks' time, on Monday at the usual time of 6 o'clock, with the aim of finishing it by the end of the summer.

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